Extended Essay

Subject: Economics

Title

The reasons behind the irrational exuberance of the Indian stock market during the covid pandemic from 2020-2021

Research Question

To what extent has the irrational exuberance of traders influenced the Indian stock market from 2020-2021?

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Introduction:

Anyone familiar with online trading can only wonder in amazement when looking at *figures 1&2*. On one hand you can see the total number of COVID cases rising if not proliferating and on the other you see an increase of India's Nifty50 market index which defies the very fundamental ecosystem of an economy. It is quite perplexing. The fact of the matter is that it contradicts economic theory. It is similar in complexity to defying the laws of gravity. On the 30th of March 2020, India received an unforeseen threat. A new pandemic named COVID-19 took the nation by storm, thrusting the market into disarray as cases started doubling everyday which then tripled and proliferated as seen in *figure 1***.** Experts predicted the market to crash, similar to the great depression of 2008, investors steeled themselves for a Kondratieff winter. Yet, surprisingly, to everyone's dismay, the stock market dipped, then proceeded to rise, undeterred by the rampage of the coronavirus indicated by *figure 2***.** As cases for COVID-19 increased, the valuation of the stock market rose with it. The overall ethos of this essay is to find out the reasons for this irrational exuberance of the stock market, as well as to highlight the main reasons why this unconventional economic phenomenon occurred. I will be analyzing the irrational exuberance of the Indian stock market, specifically the Nifty 50 stock index during a time period from 2020 March till 2021 March. Though liquidity is one of the key drivers of an active stock market or a marketplace in general, this survey and study is aimed at understanding more socio-economic reasons behind this increase in liquidity and buyer appetite that led to the irrationality in the market as a whole. This essay is an attempt to find the compelling economic

reasons behind the irrational behavior of the stock market when the economy is in peril and the ambiguity and anarchy is at its peak. Thus leading me to formulate the Research Question: "To what extent has the irrational exuberance of traders influenced the Indian stock market from 2020-2021?"

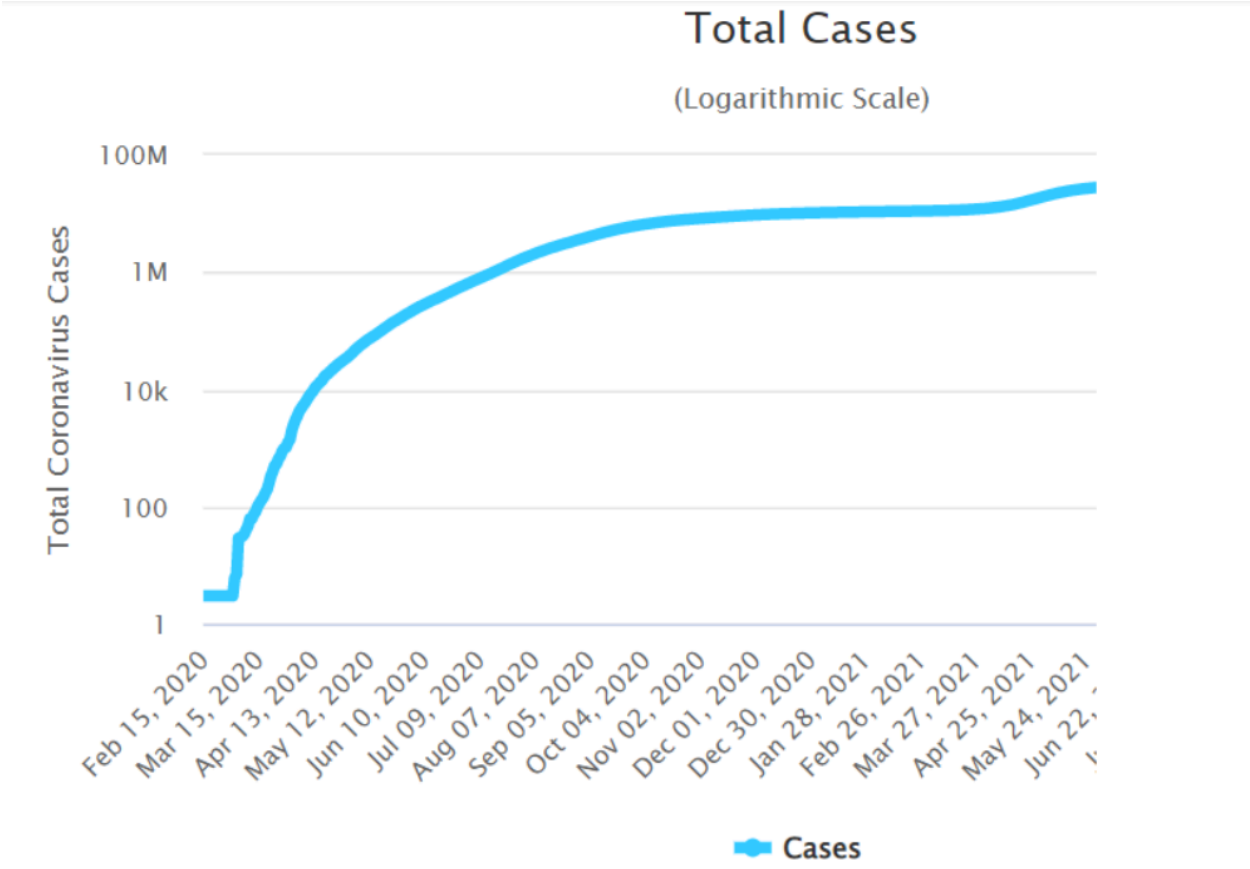


Figure 1

[1]

[1] "India." *Worldometer*, www.worldometers.info/coronavirus/country/india/.



Figure 2

[2]

Methodology:-

Primary Research:

To most effectively come to terms with what exactly is causing the irrational behavior in the stock market, I made an online survey using google forms, which was to be sent to fifteen investors in the stock market who I know through familial connections.

[2] Moneycontrol.com. "Nifty >> NSE Nifty Live,Sensex Nifty,Nifty Stocks,NSE Market Live,NSE Stocks Market,NSE NIFTY." *English*, Moneycontrol, www.moneycontrol.com/indian-indices/nifty-50-9.html.

These investors then sent the survey to their friends, so on and so forth. So far I have received 23 responses and continue to receive more. The questions for the survey and the reasoning behind asking these questions are summarized in the appendix at the bottom of the essay.

From the gathered data various economic variables are correlated, establishing a cause and effect relationship between the primary data and the irrational exuberance of the Indian stock market, thus forming the backbone of my extended essay and conclusion. The primary research findings are also substantiated with secondary research knowledge, confirming the reasons behind the economic conundrum. If there exists a correlation, an investigation was conducted on the behavior pattern that is responsible for it. The relevant details regarding these findings are as follows:-

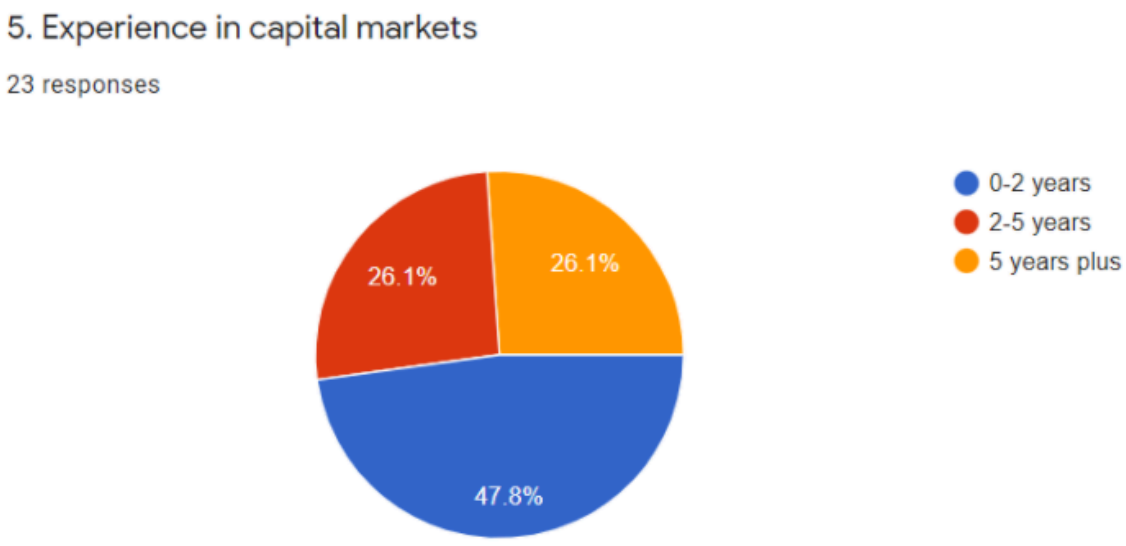


Figure 3

Of the 23 responses we have received, 76.2% of the respondents are new traders with an experience below 5 years and 47.6 % are traders with less than 2 years as shown in *figure 3.* A significant number in terms of how young and inexperienced the trader profile of the market is,

or has become due to the impact of the Coronavirus pandemic.

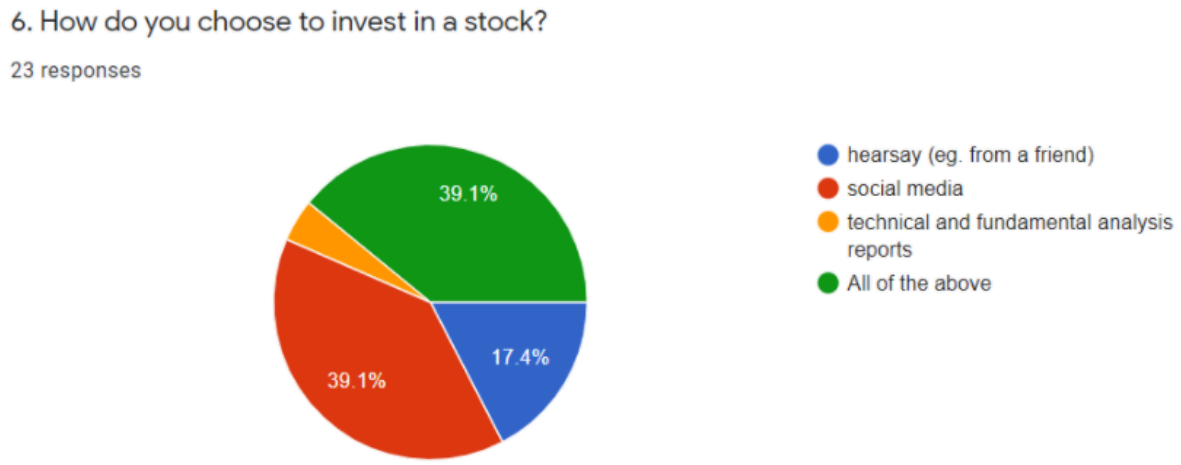


Figure 4

Figure 4 displays how the new age trader has little or few concern in terms of the basic fundamentals of trading. Historically, a trade in the stock market is based on pure analytics whether it is fundamental, technical or a combination of both. A good trade is backed by solid research where there is little room for speculation or word of mouth. One can only wonder how the dynamics of the trade have changed, particularly with the dependency on social media and traders placing their blind trust in hearsay.

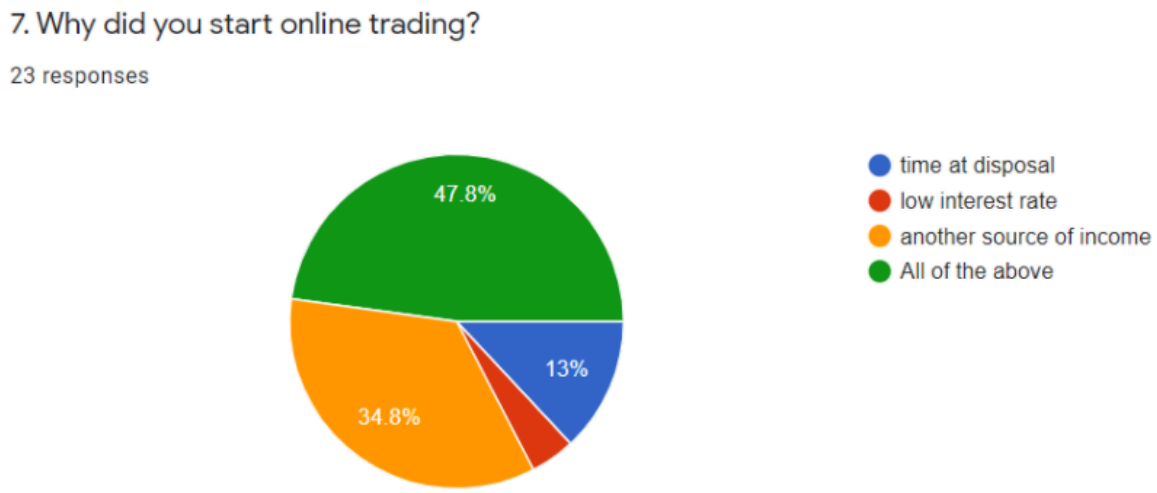


Figure 5

Figure 5 is a clear indication of how the pandemic has influenced activity in capital markets. The Indian trader, on average, has more idle time and is looking for an alternative source of income. We see a single digit response in terms of the response relating to low interest rate. This is a strategic and vital piece of information because fewer people are considering interest rates. This is most probably due to the fact that they have little interest in fixed income and low risk or they have significantly less savings due to unemployment as well as lowered business and consumer confidence to leverage the low interest rates in the economy.

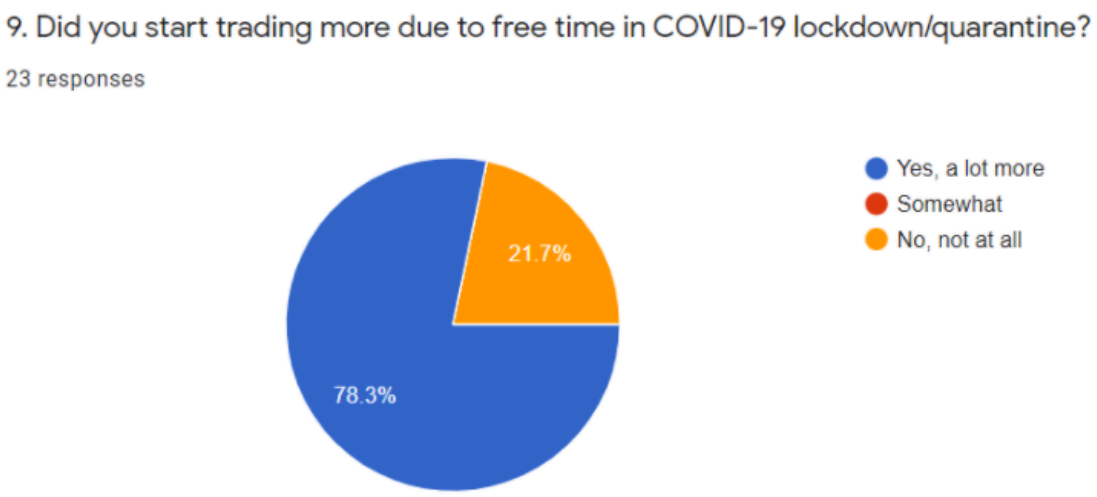


Figure 6

Figure 6 displays a key response related to the pandemic and the idle state of the investor. 78.3% started trading more due to free time in the pandemic. This highlights the social factors at play.

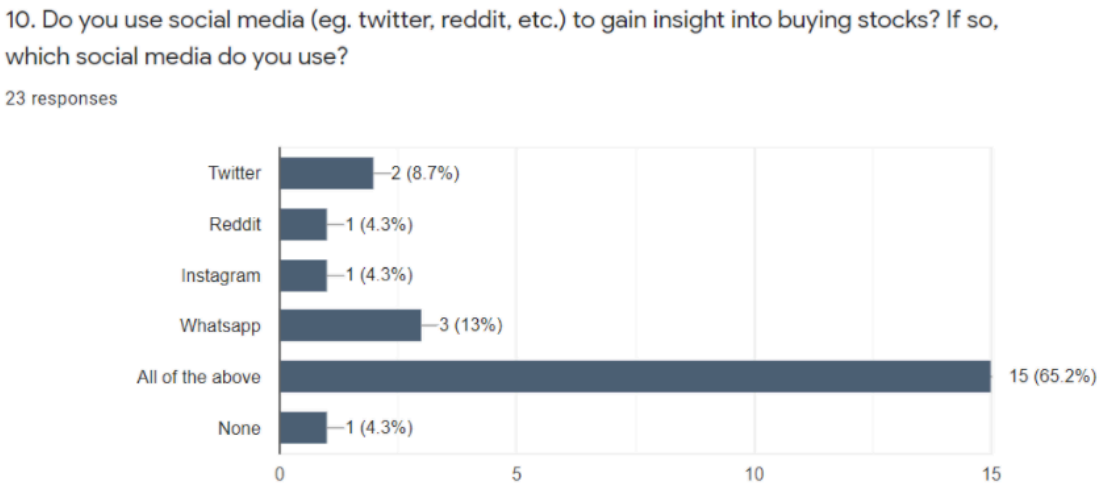


Figure 7

Figure 7 is crucial in determining how much social media influences the populace in buying a stock. Only 4.3% do not rely on any social media.

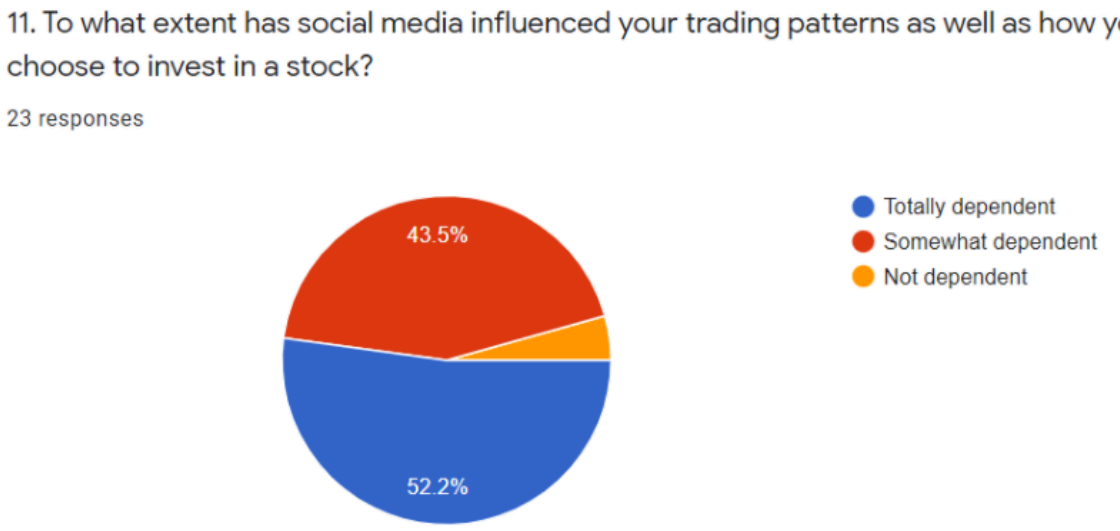


Figure 8

Figure 8 shows a 95.3% response in terms of social media dependency for investment decisions, with 52.2% being totally dependent on social media.

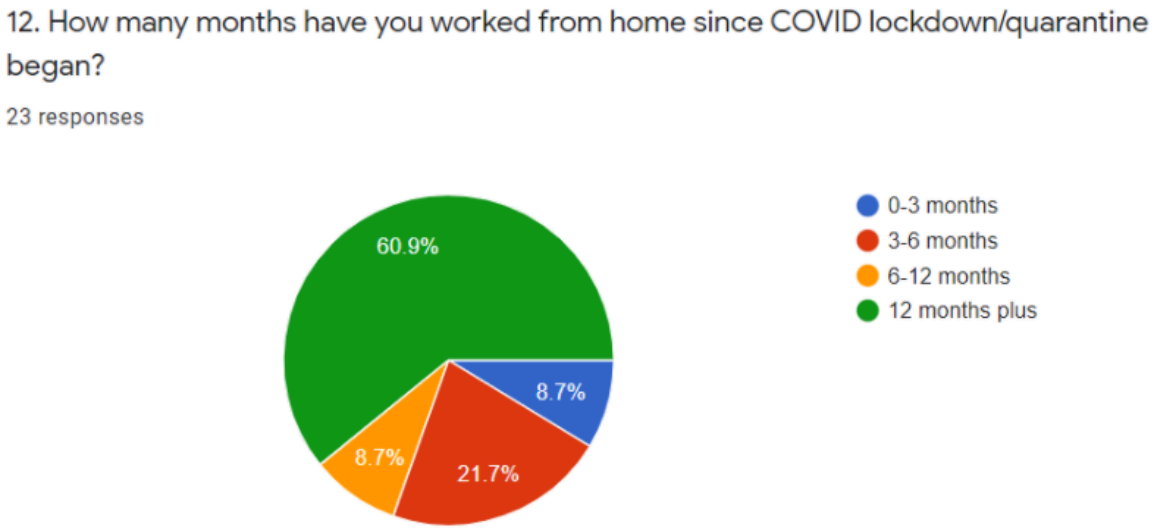


Figure 9

Figure 9 shows how a large portion of respondents have been idle during the pandemic.

This is another key indication that socio-economic factors like the pandemic, play a large role in the stock market. In brief, my primary research has aided me to find out the dynamics of the investing community, as well as the main socio-economic factors at play when analyzing the irrational exuberance of the market.

Secondary research:

I scoured the internet searching for articles which detail the various factors that contributed to the market's irrationality during the time period to supplement the findings from my primary research, and to find further socio-economic variables at play. I did this mainly to portray the issue in a macroeconomic context. Additionally, I searched for articles delineating the deteriorating state of the Indian economy at the time, to compare it to the ameliorating stock market. To say the least, I found more than enough evidence from credible sources to formulate my arguments in a cohesive, and conclusive manner. It goes without saying that in keeping with the timeframe of the investigation, I made sure that the research I had gathered fell within the bounds of my prescribed time period.

In some capacity, instability always exists in the stock market and the economy, just like the existence of a natural rate of unemployment, making it nigh impossible to derive and show the cause and effect relationships of all permutations and combinations in the economy that resulted in irrational exuberance in the stock market during this time. However, with the data that I have gathered and researched, I can come to a reasonable conclusion on the main stimulus behind the phenomenon.

The role of liquidity and its economic relevance in an equity market scenario:

Liquidity is the degree to which a security can be quickly purchased or sold in the market at a price reflecting its current value. Liquidity in finance refers to the ease with which a security or an asset can be converted into cash at market price.[3]

The fundamental reason behind the surge in index is an increase in the number of buyers and sellers which corresponds to demand and supply which in turn led to the understanding of the increased liquidity in the market. The primary research points to the direction of liquidity, secondary research was aimed at understanding the reasons behind the increase in liquidity and hence the demand and supply. So, in effect, this essay is also looking at the possibility of the reasons behind the increase in the total number of investors in the market during the period relevant to this essay topic**.**

Reasons for increased liquidity-

FDI/FII and portfolio investment, and the fall of the Indian rupee: Foreign Direct Investment plays a key role in economic development and market liquidity. It is when a firm has its headquarters somewhere in the world, and decides to operate another branch/ part of its business in another part of the world, for example a firm's headquarters may be in the United States Of America, but operates another branch in India.

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[3]*Module 3- Liquidity Management.pdf - Module 3 Liquidity ...* Polytechnic University Of The Phillipines, www.coursehero.com/file/95939480/Module-3-LIQUIDITY-MANAGEMENTpdf/.

Foreign Institutional Investment is defined as investment in a country outside of the one in which it is registered or headquartered.[4] We saw an increased appetite amongst FDI and FII in the Indian stock market since the Indian rupee fell against the US dollar amidst the initial covid scare of early 2020, as seen in *Figure 10*[5]. FDI/FII activity later surged during this time due to the attractive low price of the Indian rupee traded against the US dollar. Hence attracting the highest ever total FDI inflow during the financial year 2020-21. This can be seen in *Figure 11*[6]:

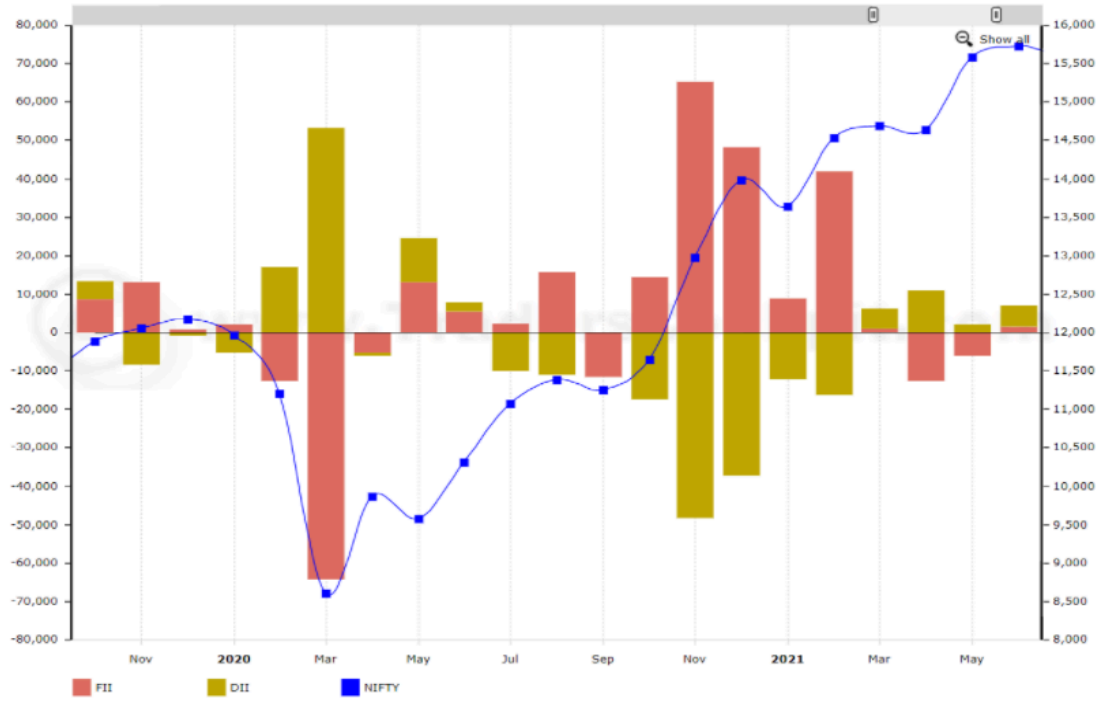


Figure 11

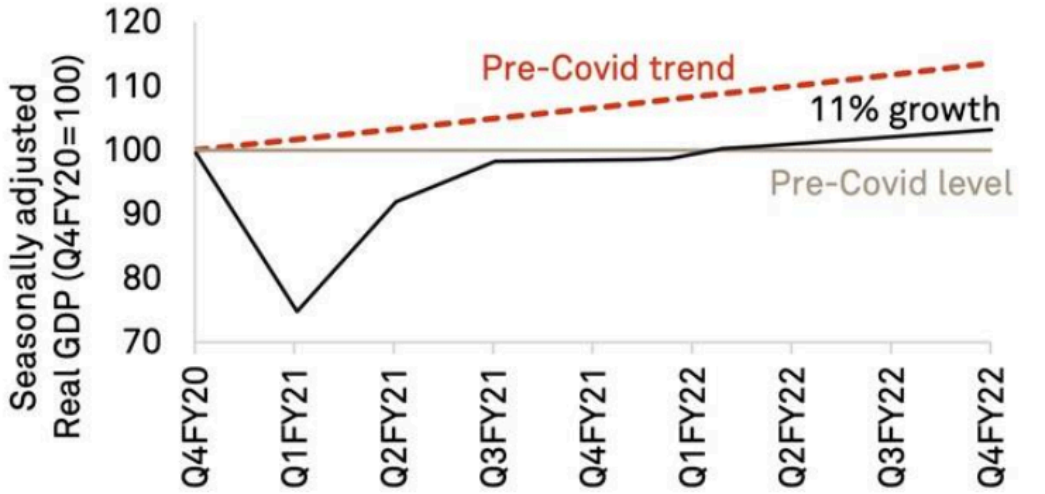
[4]Chen, James. "Foreign Institutional Investor (FII)." *Investopedia*, Investopedia, 8 Feb. 2022, www.investopedia.com/terms/f/fii.asp.

[5]"USD INR Chart." *Investing.com India*, in.investing.com/currencies/usd-inr-chart.

[6]"Foreign Direct Investment: Make in India." *Foreign Direct Investment | Make In India*, www.makeinindia.com/foreign-direct-investment#:~:text=FDI%20in%20India%20has%20followed,April%202000%20(%24592.08%20Bn).

Detailing the state of India's economy:

When COVID-19 first hit the shores of Kerala, and spread throughout India, the world's fastest growing economy hit a wall. far from safe from the ferocious nature of the coronavirus. Private consumption and investment are the two biggest powerhouses of India's economic growth, and both were nullified by the virus. The economy was in downturn, bordering an impending recession after the first wave hit in 2020, shown in Figure 12 below displays that the pre-covid long-term growth trend for real GDP, (potential GDP) is much higher than India's real GDP, indicating that the economy was in its first technical recession for the first time in history in the first half of fiscal year 2020, peaking in march of 2020, with two following consecutive quarters of negative growth.



Note: The flat line refers to the indexed level of GDP in Q4FY20

Source: Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), CEIC, CRISIL

Figure 12

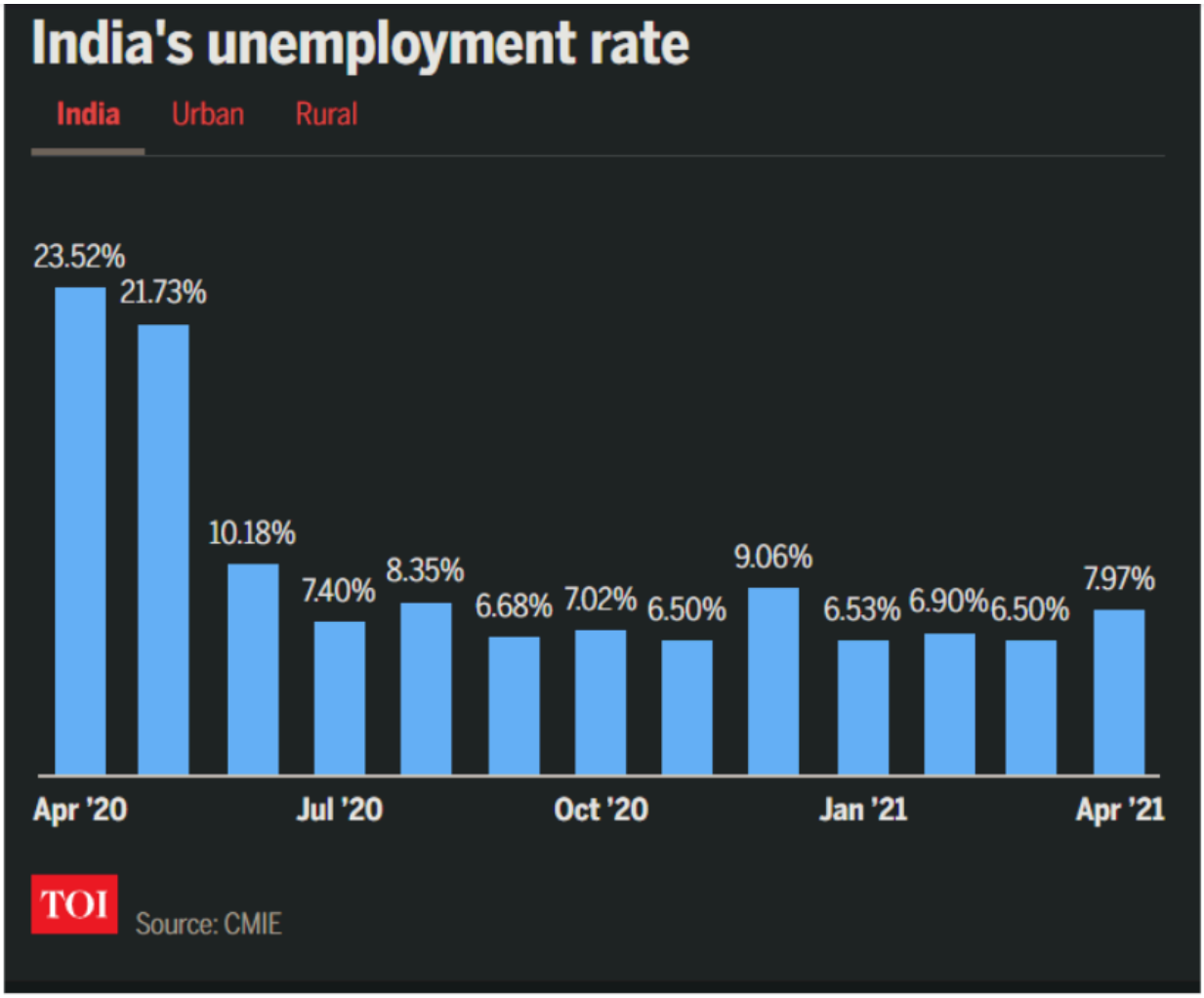


Figure 13

The unemployment rate exceeded India's natural rate of unemployment three fold in April and May 2020 as shown above in *figure 13*[7], a bonafide indicator of an economic downturn. Lockdowns were fully imposed, India's colossal 2.9 trillion dollar empire remained shut during the lockdown period, save for some essential services and activities.

[7] Payal Bhattacharya / TIMESOFINDIA.COM / May 30, 2021. "First Technical Recession, SENSEX at 50k: How Economy Performed in 2 Years of Modi 2.0 - Times of India." *The Times of India*, TOI, timesofindia.indiatimes.com/business/india-business/first-technical-recession-sensex-at-50k-how-economy-performed-in-2-years-of-modi-2-0/articleshow/83085454.cms.

As shops, commercial spaces, factories, transport services, markets, business establishments and more were shut down, the lockdown had a devastating impact on slowing down the economy. This is not to mention that India has one of the largest informal sectors relative to its economy in the world, it accounts for more than 80 percent of non-agricultural employment[8]. India's GDP growth had crashed 23.9% in response to the center's no notice lockdown. India's GDP shrank 7.3% in 2020-21, the worst decline ever observed since the ministry had started collecting GDP statistics in 1996[7]. However, if informal sectors were taken into consideration, this contraction would easily go above and beyond 8%. This was far and away, the Indian economy's worst performance in any financial year since the nation attained independence in 1947. Surveys conducted by the Centre For Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) show steep rises in unemployment rates, in the range of 7.9% to 12% during the April-June quarter of 2021[9]. The stock market is usually a mirror image of the economy's health, as the two are dependent on one another. Yet the stock market continues to rise while all the economy's vital signs are in peril, in a state which mirrors the characteristics of an economic boom or recovery.

Due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the amount of investors in the market as a whole increased exponentially. Juggernauts in online trading platforms Zerodha and Upstox reported 52.26% and 99.034% increases in active users between 2020-2021 respectively[10].

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[8]"Informal Economy in South Asia (ILO in India)." *Informal Economy in South Asia (ILO in India)*, www.ilo.org/newdelhi/areasofwork/informal-economy/lang--en/index.htm.

[9] Mangla, Shreyansh. "Impact of Covid-19 on Indian Economy." *Times of India Blog*, 11 July 2021, timesofindia.indiatimes.com/readersblog/shreyansh-mangla/impact-of-covid-19-on-indian-economy-2-35042/.

[10]"UPSTOX Active Customers and Complaints Detail." *Top Share Broker India - Reviews,Comparison and Offers*, www.topsharebrokers.com/active-customers/upstox/33/.

The reason behind this increase in the user base could be debated, however most agree with the notion that due to the surge in unemployment in the economy following numerous lockdowns, India's now unemployed labor force sought new means of sustaining themselves. With the rise of technology came the ease of accessibility to new income sources. One such income source accessible to the masses was online stock trading, and with everyone and their mother having access to a mobile phone and online information, new entrants into the market came in droves. However, it wasn't purely necessity that drove this demand for a new income source. Many were made redundant due to a decline in mass business confidence and sharp rise in unemployment**,** shown in *Figures 5,6* and *13,* and even with a secondary income source, had more than enough free time to spend at home, investing time into developing a tertiary income source would be more than ideal, especially when times of economic adversity are not as infrequent as we once envisioned.

Barriers to entry in trading and the arrival of online trading platforms and brokerages:

The barriers to entry for new investors to enter into the market are relatively low. In the past, trades were done through brokers and investors were considered a different breed of people due to lack of related information. People were of the belief that stock markets resembled a gambling dens and whatever investments which were at stake were doomed.

[10]"UPSTOX Active Customers and Complaints Detail." *Top Share Broker India - Reviews,Comparison and Offers*, www.topsharebrokers.com/active-customers/upstox/33/.

With limited information and lots of bavardage about the minimum investment required by the brokerage houses and portfolio managers, many decided that stock markets are reserved for the wealthy and for people with lots of money to lose.

Nowadays, with relatively cheap digital data available within the touch of fingertips, the public, with investment appetite who otherwise thought of the stock market as an alien, started pouring into the market. Indispensable and expensive stock brokers gave way to online brokerage platforms like Zerodha or Upstox. The taboo affair of the Indian stock markets for the average Indian Joe, suddenly became a possibility with enormous rewards. The present-day trading apps, combined with the vast availability of smartphones, cheap data, and the arrival of online trading platforms like Zerodha, Upstox, Angel Broking etc, have made stock trading an easy affair. The amount needed to open a trading account on Zerodha is a mere rs. 200/-, and Zerodha does not require any minimum amount in a trading account. Consequently, with a barrier of no minimum and ease of trade with apps in the convenience of one's own smartphone, the Indian public with very basic knowledge of the market's dynamics and a lot of convenient time at their disposal went headlong into the market, seeking lucrative returns.

Price and Demand:

Demand is the quantity of a good that consumers are willing and able to purchase at various prices during a given period of time. The stock market, though on the surface, and to the layman, may seem like a complex number crunching machine, at its core, it is a market, like the name implies, just for equities with varying price levels rather than physical goods and services.

Therefore, the mechanisms of price, supply, and demand are key factors that play in the irrational exuberance of the market and can therefore be analyzed.

When referring to “Stocks" the total number of companies that are traded in the stock market is taken into account. It is a collection of all the main stocks in the stock market.
For example the Nifty 50 stock index is an index corresponding to the market behavior at any given day of the companies in the Nifty 50 stock index basket. We consider all the companies that are traded in the market. When the valuation of stocks increases, more stocks are of a higher value than of a lower value in the index. We can therefore treat the stock as a good, and analyze its factors of price, supply, and demand as such.

Now that there are more investors willing and able to purchase stocks, since the liquidity in the market has increased, there are more buyers in the market, so naturally the amount of sellers of stock would also fill the gap, and increase. Given the fact that the number of stocks available in the market is constant, an increase in demand will therefore result in an increase in price. Back to the issue at hand, demand as a whole increases for purchases of most stocks.

This is due in part to a number of non-price determinants of demand: Firstly, the investors’ trading patterns: New entrants into the market are inexperienced. They seek information and trading methods, hence they turn to the internet for advice, and listen to hearsay, social media, and anyone online ‘qualified’ enough to give trading advice as seen in *figures 4,7 & 8* in my primary research findings. Facebook, Reddit, Twitter, etc. are the new analysts. Analysts tend to command a subscription fee or some form of deposit for their regular commentary on stocks.

Anyone who shouts more gets more readership and audience. The underbelly of the real matter often gets dissipated during this hullabaloo.

This phenomenon is transnational and India has seen its fair share. For instance Tesla, making fewer cars than what Toyota makes in a quarter, has a market cap of USD 714.25 billion which is higher than the combined market caps of Toyota and Volkswagen, the two biggest automobile manufacturers in terms of vehicle production, with only USD 208.64 Billion and USD 139.37 Billion as of April 2021 respectively[11]. Though considering the first mover advantage of Tesla in the EV space, this valuation is unbelievable. The advantages of first movers include time to develop economies of scale and cost-efficient ways of producing or delivering a product compared to a competitor. But their technology is not unique and a lot more EVs are entering the market. Competitive EVs are rolled out by the automobile behemoths with a much better production capacity and dealer network. Now that makes Tesla a stock that is highly valued.

Yet, the ruckus it makes in social media spaces such as twitter, by its onerous bombastic founder with celebrity status, made it a golden goose for the younger enthusiastic clientele of the American stock market. Similarly we see the same trend in India. Though we do not have a single candidate like Tesla as a representative for such irrationality in the market, we have many small caps in the market that are similar in nature.

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[11]"Largest Automakers by Market Capitalization." *CompaniesMarketCap.com - Companies Ranked by Market Capitalization*, companiesmarketcap.com/automakers/largest-automakers-by-market-cap/.

In the primary survey and its findings where we saw the response from 23 people in the investing community, we see the palpable example of the reliance on social media on their investment decisions as shown in *Figures 7&8*. The new investors are more reliant on social media for information and associated trading decisions.

Another key driver in the irrationality we see in the market.

With the market on the rise and with lots of time to spare, the general populace consumed the advice of social media with a voracious appetite and excitement. Analysts took a back seat while the users of reddit and facebook cultivated herd investment.

Thirdly, it has to do with the inelasticity of demand: Given the fact that the number of stocks is a constant, the market has also increased due to the inelasticity of demand. Due to mass unemployment and decline in both consumer and business confidence, consumers started searching for new sources of income. When you are locked down, with little possibilities to deal with the physical social network, stock markets and shares become darlings driving up demand. Investors, spurred on by the potential benefits they may receive, as well as the necessity for a new source of income (as seen in *figure 5)* blindly throw their money at the market, driving up demand.

Finally of course, the most obvious non-price determinant of demand is that the number of consumers in the market have increased due to the aforementioned reasons in this essay. Therefore, on average, those willing and able to invest in stock will also increase, aggrandizing demand.

Illustrating market forces of demand, supply, and price:-



Figure 14

Due to the influence of the aforementioned non-price determinants of demand, the demand curve shifts to the right from D1 to D2 shown in *figure 14*[12], moving from point A to B at the initial price, P1. This results in a shortage equal to the difference between Q2 and Q1 as indicated in the diagram. At point B, the quantity demanded Q2, due to the increase in demand to D2, is larger than quantity supplied, Q1. The price of Stock therefore begins to rise and will continue to rise until the shortage has disappeared.

This happens at price P2 and quantity Q3, given by the point of intersection of the supply curve, S with the new demand curve, D2, at point C. This is a microeconomic explanation of why the stock market has risen in the past two years, caused by the influence of non-price determinants of the demand.

Conclusion:

Irrationality and increased funds at one's disposal is a toxic recipe for disaster and short lived excitement. Such is the case of the capital market. Though this essay is not intended to solve the complicated puzzle of what the direction of the stock market is in a given frame of time, I could conclude the reasons for this irrational exuberance in the market. Liquidity and the irrationality that is fuelled by ignorance, free time, inelasticity of demand and social media-directed herd investment behavior, which all drive up demand and therefore the price of the stock market. Irrationality seldom provides positive results and it should be said that this new investment landscape fits the definition. A landscape where social media rules in all aspects of our life whether it is private or public is bound to bring turmoil.

[12] Tragakes, Ellie. *Economics for the IB Diploma*. Cambridge University Press, 2020.

Ergo, providing some insight into the solution for the proposed question: “To what extent has the irrational exuberance of traders influenced the Indian stock market from 2020-2021?”.

Be that as it may, there exist limitations to my results. I made use of results from primary research to draw my conclusions, where I sent a survey to 23 traders. This sample size is small, and it could be argued that it doesn’t completely represent investor behavior as well as a large sample can eg. 100 people. In addition to this, I did take some liberties in terms of what secondary sources I had used, most were reliable, yet there are one or two whose source reliability could be questioned to some extent.

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Appendix:-

The following is the questionnaire for my Extended Essay and the justifications behind asking said questions:-

No.	Question	Justification for asking question
1	Age	Fundamental understanding of Trader
2	Level of education: What is the highest degree or level of schooling you have completed?	Data interpretation and analytical skills , socio-economic data.
3	Income	Understanding the level of risk involved in trading
4	Employment status	Whether idle time is a factor .
6	Experience in capital markets	Expertise in trading
7	How do you choose to invest in a stock?	Risk appetite.
8.	Why did you start online trading?	Reasons for involvement in the market.
9	What is your trading strategy?	How planned a trader is in terms of an eventuality.
10	Did you start trading more due to free time in COVID-19 lockdown/quarantine?	Illustrates the influence of pandemic.
11	Do you use social media (eg. twitter, reddit, etc.) to gain insight into buying stocks? If so, which social media do you use?	Understanding one of the key factors in determining irrationality in the market.
12	How many months have you worked from home since COVID lockdown/quarantine began?	How idle time has influenced stock trading.